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Rahul Mishra

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From non-alignment to multi-alignment: assessing India's foreign policy shift

Rahul Mishra 

Centre for ASEAN Regionalism Universiti Malaya (CARUM), Asia-Europe Institute, Kuala Lumpur, Malaysia

ABSTRACT

Establishing a non-aligned bloc at the height of the power politics-ridden Cold War era was one of the most profound normative contributions India made to the modern international order. This article argues that NAM was a pragmatic yet principled approach to dealing with a world dominated by divisive power politics. For India, non-alignment still lives on to a certain extent in the form of its spirited defence of strategic autonomy and the recent iteration of 'multi-alignment' in Indian foreign policy to deal with an uncertain world.

KEYWORDS

Cold War; India; Jawaharlal Nehru; Multi-alignment; Non-Aligned Movement (NAM); strategic autonomy; world order

Introduction

The Non-Aligned Movement (NAM) played two critical roles in shaping the post-Second World War world order. First, it aided in stabilising the bipolar world dynamics, which were prone to conflict. Second, it provided post-colonial states with a common platform to raise their interests and concerns in shaping the international order. NAM was instrumental in proposing new set of normative ideas to the international system, some of which were inducted into the system eventually. Regional organisations such as ASEAN (Association of Southeast Asian Nations) took inspiration from NAM in ways more than one. The role played by India in shaping NAM – and by extension in influencing the international order – is still underappreciated, particularly among the western international relations theorists.

At the height of the Cold War, when India was grappling with an excessively polarised international system, NAM turned out to be an effective and rather powerful diplomatic tool in ensuring India's strategic autonomy in the international arena. For the most part, it contributed to strengthening the cherished principles of keeping foreign policy independent and even-handed. India contributed to NAM in creating its normative agency, which was established as a forum comprising countries from Africa and Asia that believed in discarding ideological-material rivalries among states and in pursuing their own paths to growth and development. In the early post-World War II era, newly-independent states such as India, Egypt, Indonesia, and Yugoslavia possessed diplomatic capacities that allowed them to swing international opinion away from either of the two power blocs. Their assistance was pivotal in shaping international opinions on key issues.

In most cases, the support of the non-aligned bloc was not only crucial but was also seen as a voice of reason, which is why both the US-led Western bloc and the USSR-led Socialist bloc tried to woo the NAM countries.

Such has been the impact of those early successes in India's foreign policy that even today – when India has drawn closer than ever to the US and is a part of the Quad (Quadrilateral Security Dialogue) multi-aligned and principled inclusivity continue to prevail as a foreign policy priority. In recent years, Indian Minister of External Affairs S. Jaishankar and foreign secretary Harsh Vardhan Shringla have repeatedly underscored the critical role strategic autonomy plays in shaping Indian foreign policy choices. S. Jaishankar, the External Affairs Minister in Prime Minister Narendra Modi's cabinet (2019–2024), has described it as India's pursuit of multi-alignment (Jaishankar, 2020). In his recent speech at the Raisina Dialogue, in 2022, Dr. Jaishankar also acknowledged that the term 'multi-alignment' was first floated by Shashi Tharoor, an Indian politician (Tharoor, 2022).

India's non-aligned foreign policy: origin and evolution

A newly independent India's foreign and security policies and practices were heavily influenced by its more-than-a-century-old struggle for independence. During the freedom struggle, Indian freedom fighters realised that India was not alone in its freedom struggle; there were dozens of countries in the non-western world fighting against the exploitation at the hands of the Western Imperialist powers.

Years of violent and non-violent struggles and systemic factors of global politics had a considerable impact on these countries. Consequently, a majority of these countries perceived their independence as the 'dawn of a new era' – an era beyond the 'dark ages' where nations, particularly the newly independent ones, must live in peace and harmony. True, some countries had teething troubles in their nation-building and ethnic reconciliation processes or even had boundary disputes with neighbours; but, none of these challenges were as daunting as the presence of their former colonial rulers. The non-alignment policy was a direct outcome of that collective understanding and experience of political leaders and people across the Afro-Asian political spectrum.

In addition to India's long-standing tradition of peace and non-violence, the Gandhian influence, and a firm belief in peaceful co-existence with others in complete harmony, several key international conferences and meetings involving the thought leaders of the Afro-Asian world played a significant role in shaping the non-alignment policy of India and its many partners. India realised that it was neither necessary nor practical for it to join either of the power blocs.

The Brussels conference

In assessing the role conception of NAM by its constituent members, it is essential to evaluate the role played by the 1927 Brussels Conference. Convened in the Egmont Palace in Brussels in February 1927, the League against Imperialism and Colonial Oppression meeting was attended by 175 delegates representing countries across the world. More than 60% of participants were from countries under colonial rule. Jawaharlal Nehru (along with Virendranath Chattopadhyaya) participated in the conference as the

representative of the Indian National Congress. Other notable participants included Mohammad Hatta from Indonesia, Willi Münzenberg, Romain Rolland, Albert Einstein, and Henri Barbusse.

The deliberations inspired the representatives from the colonised countries, including Nehru and other Asian leaders, to create a forum that would not side with the imperialist powers. That is why the Indonesian leader Sukarno later acknowledged the Brussels conference and the League against Imperialism and Colonial Oppression as ‘the start of an eventually victorious global liberation movement’ (Hatherley, 2021).

Asian relations conference

The Asian Relations Conference (ARC) is acknowledged as one of India’s most significant Pan-Asian initiatives which ‘constituted the first appearance of Asia in international politics’ (Mézard, 2006, p. 20). The first ARC was held from 23 March to 2 April 1947. It was attended by 231 official invitees representing as many as 30 countries/entities/institutions. Jawaharlal Nehru described the conference outcome as ‘an amazing success from every point of view’ and ‘a beginning of a new era in Asian history’ (Muni & Mishra, 2019, p. 80). Highlighting the collective aspirations of participants in his inaugural speech, Nehru said (Asian Relations, 1948, p. 2):

It so happened that we in India convened this Conference, but the idea of such a conference arose simultaneously in many minds and in many countries of Asia. There was a widespread urge and awareness that the time had come for us, peoples of Asia, to meet together, to hold together and to advance together. It was not only a vague desire but a compulsion of events that forced all of us to think along these lines . . . because of this, the invitation we in India sent out, brought an answering echo and a magnificent response from every country of Asia.

The conference helped firm up a common Pan-Asian identity of the newly independent countries of Asia. Together, these countries made some positive contributions to the United Nations including their support for the call for Indonesian independence. It also paved the way for greater cooperation between India and Indonesia and led to the convening of the Bandung Conference in 1955.

Bandung conference

While it is true that conceptually, the Brussels conference, the Asian Relations Conference, and India and the rest of Asia’s struggle for independence played their parts in shaping the nature and scope of the NAM, it was the Bandung conference that played a pivotal role in the launch of NAM. Termed by Sukarno as the ‘first intercontinental conference of coloured peoples in the history of mankind’ (Ministry of Foreign Affairs, Indonesia, 1955), the conference was held on 18–24 April 1955 and witnessed 29 countries in attendance.

Growing Asian solidarity was precisely the reason why the West felt uncomfortable about the Bandung Conference. The United Kingdom, the United States, Australia, and France did not like the idea of such a conference. Staying non-aligned in an intensely polarised world was an uphill task, especially when the US and the UK were trying their best to derail the Bandung meeting and its idea of a non-aligned, norm-based solidarity

among its members. The American and British attempts to sabotage the Bandung meeting naturally led to a general impression that the 'USSR was perhaps more civil in its diplomacy.' As Acharya (2017, p. 78) opines:

... The US along with Britain actively and openly sought to undermine by influencing the positions – even to the extent of providing anti-communist background papers and draft resolutions to its friends and allies ... It remains an important question whether NAM would have taken a different, less anti-American course had the administration treated the Asian neutrals with greater empathy and tactfulness and engaged them directly (rather than relying on Britain).

Acharya rightly points out that the onus of shooring the 'Asian neutrals' lay with the US (and the Western bloc) and not the other side as some Indian foreign policy experts argue. Acharya (2017, p. 79) states,

Instead of seeking to manipulate the Bandung Conference through its proxies, the US might have shown more diplomatic tolerance for the event, which was by no means anti-Western talk fest and sought dialogue and understanding with the Asian neutrals that were the official sponsors of the meeting. A logical extension of this alternative might have been US support for the creation of a multilateral regional system led by India and Indonesia, involving Japan and Australia and with the eventual participation of the PRC. Instead, the US chose to base its East Asian security strategy on SEATO and its bilateral alliances (the hub-and-spoke system).

The Asian Relations Conference started off on a strong note, and the Bandung conference continued the momentum. It not only disapproved of Western assumptions about Afro-Asian solidarity but also indicated that the non-western world had a normative agency in shaping the international order. Many of these issues are still reflected in ASEAN deliberations. Bandung challenged the ideational superiority notions of the West, which, as Acharya (2014) argues, contributed to shaping the 'Western resistance to the political aspirations of the newly independent countries for equality and political autonomy'.

Nehru's role

There is a general consensus that independent India's foreign policy formulations, particularly the non-alignment policy, were deeply linked with the Indian freedom struggle experiences. It was shaped by India's traditions of peace and nurtured by the Gandhian values of non-violence. Some even argue that since its inception, Indian National Congress resolutions on foreign policy issues were shaped by norms and principles that subsequently shaped Non-alignment (Prasad, 1983). As India's first Prime Minister, Jawaharlal Nehru emerged as the architect of India's foreign policy, particularly concerning India's approach to the post-World War international order. Highlighting Nehru's contribution, Damodaran argues (Damodaran, 1983, p. 48):

The idea of non-alignment from power blocs, as distinct from the earlier concept of neutrality or the later pejorative phrase 'neutralism' is associated both in its origin and in its evolution with Jawaharlal Nehru along with three or four leaders (Josip Broz Tito, Kwame Nkrumah, and Sukarno).

A newly independent India was mindful of the intricacies of the post-war world order. In his statements, Nehru also mentioned the possible role of ‘to be freed’ Asian countries. In his book, *Discovery of India*, Nehru states that the post-World War II international order would be dominated by the two superpowers – the US and USSR – and their bilateral dynamics would shape the international order. For him, however, a more prominent concern was the role and space for India’s Afro-Asian peers – a sentiment that resonated with Josip Broz Tito and Kwame Nkrumah as well. Highlighting these concerns (in the wake of a heightened US-USSR rivalry), Nehru writes (Nehru, 1946, pp. 546–547):

Where do the hundreds of millions of Asia and Africa come into this picture? They have become increasingly conscious of themselves and their destiny, and at the same time are also world conscious. Large numbers of them follow world events with interest. For them, inevitably, the test of each move or happening is this: Does it help towards our liberation? Does it end the domination of one country over another? Will it enable us to live freely the life of our choice in co-operation with others? Does it bring equality and equal opportunity for nations as well as groups within each nation? Does it hold forth the promise of an early liquidation of poverty and illiteracy and bring better living conditions? They are nationalistic but this nationalism seeks no dominion over, or interference with, others. They welcome all attempts at world co-operation and the establishment of an international order, but they wonder and suspect if this may not be another device for continuing the old domination.

Summing up Nehru’s conception of NAM, Acharya (2017, p. 189) argues:

Nehru’s concept of ‘non-involvement’ (which later fused into the broader doctrine of ‘non-alignment’) was practically an adaptive extension of the Western principle of non-intervention at a time when the two superpowers were violating the doctrine with impunity.

The above statement highlights the concerns Nehru had about the emergent international order. He was keen to ensure that India and its peers got their due in the international system – that they become ‘rule makers’ and not mere ‘rule takers’. The Asian Relations Conference and the Bandung Conference amply demonstrated those aspirations.

The raison d’être of NAM

Faced with centuries of colonial exploitation at the hands of the Western Imperialist powers, it was natural for the newly independent non-western nations to keep their foreign and security policies independent, neutral, and away from any allegiance to either of the superpowers and their allies. Like India, many of these countries had to fight a long battle for their independence, which shaped their desire to play their due part in post-World War global politics. Some of the leading countries were ‘particularly keen to make contributions to the continuing struggle for peace and freedom. Such urges could find fulfilment only through the policy of non-alignment’ (Prasad, 1983).

This preference to keep away from bloc politics was primarily driven by newly independent states’ desire to sustain the international pressure and survive and prosper domestically and internationally. Under the leadership of towering Afro-Asian statesmen, many of these newly independent countries enthusiastically embraced NAM and its vision. Later, as the pitfalls of bloc politics surfaced, the normative role of the NAM

became more and more evident, but in the process, the Cold War power politics and politico-economic miseries of its members also undermined NAM's normative role.

In its original form, NAM was an astute diplomatic move that was mindful of India's limited material capabilities. Post-partition India was economically weak and under tremendous pressure on the non-traditional security front. It had a vast population living in extreme poverty. The country was also facing a huge influx of refugees from across the border. For an economically weak and politically fragile India, it was logical to keep the focus away from a military-centric foreign policy. It was even deemed unnecessary as Nehru (unrealistically) believed in good neighbourly relations with China while trying to balance good ties with both the USSR and the US. Under such a situation, barring international security challenges, maintaining a powerful armed force or keeping it prepared for any external/out-of-area operation was perhaps deemed unnecessary – an assessment which, of course, proved detrimental to India's national security calculations vis-à-vis Pakistan and China. It is interesting to note that during those years, there was even a debate among the political elites as to whether India should keep the armed forces personnel strength intact or downsize it substantially, if not completely get rid of it. So, non-alignment was not just a principled 'dream of neutrality but was rather based on a realistic assessment of India's geopolitical situation' (Pant & Super, 2015, p. 749).

Scholars argue that being a democratic country having close ties with the UK, India was a natural fit in the western bloc (Pant & Super, 2015). Theoretically, this assessment seems sound, but it would be problematic to imagine its acceptability in a newly independent country that had struggled against British imperialism for decades. Siding with the Western bloc would have been a political disaster in a country where 'Angrezon, Bharat chhoro' (Britishers, leave India) was a popular slogan, and where the revolutionary armed fighters such as Subhas Chandra Bose were against the Western powers. To align with the Western bloc immediately after gaining independence would not have been morally right or practically feasible.

India's modest success in developing economic capabilities and failure to resolve its border disputes on time cost it dearly along the northern and north-western frontiers. The 1962 War dented India's reputation in the Afro-Asian sphere while also compelling it to search urgently for reliable defence partners and suppliers. The China-Pakistan challenge along the border kept India 'boxed-in' militarily and strategically, leaving little scope for making any substantive normative contributions at the international level. In 1971, the then Indian Prime Minister Indira Gandhi signed a treaty of friendship with the USSR (while keeping the possibility for the same open for the US also; Rasgotra, 2016). As regards Nehru's role in keeping Indian foreign policy non-aligned, he remained committed to the idea and followed it as far as possible. Several instances may be cited where, based on his idealistic assessment of the situation, instead of supporting the Soviet Bloc, he chose to side with the Western bloc.

India's unique positioning

Unlike countries such as Malaya, which later gave birth to Malaysia and Singapore, and where the transfer of power was rather peaceful and negotiated among the political elites, India had to fight for more than a century to gain its independence which was also accompanied by a partition of the country along communal lines. For former British

colonies such as Malaysia, it was easier to remain aligned with the British as the common people were not against British rule (except some Malaysian Indians, who had to pay a heavy price for supporting Subhas Bose, the Indian National Army, and the Indian National Congress). Even after India gained independence and became a separate entity, Malaya remained a part of the British Empire.

Even in Malaysia, where Tunku Abdul Rahman, a Britain-educated anti-communist political leader from the royal family, took the reins of independent Malaya, alignment with the West could not be sustained for long. Eventually, non-alignment became a guiding philosophy for Malaysian foreign policy after Tunku left office, and the 'Young Turks' took over Malaysia's political scene. By the 1980s, Malaysia became one of the staunchest anti-Western (especially during Mahathir Mohamad's Prime Ministership), non-aligned countries in Asia. After the Tunku, the political leadership in Malaysia turned away from the West, with some even advocating that as an independent, sovereign, and self-respecting country, Malaysia should not align with the West (particularly the US).

India did give the West, especially the United Kingdom, fair share of diplomatic engagement by joining the Commonwealth. Nehru also maintained cordial ties with the United Kingdom (and the West) often supporting their policies (e.g. the South Vietnam issue in 1950s). However, it would have been a political disaster to stick to the same Western powers which pushed the world into two World Wars and which were votaries of imperialism across the world. The polarised debates in Indian foreign policy discourse often point out this dilemma with neither side sufficiently explaining what could have been a better choice for India's foreign policy in its early years.

NAM and India: a critical appraisal

One of the successes of NAM was that it not only helped in reaching a consensus on major political-strategic issues of global importance but, more importantly, it also drew countries closer in dealing with shared economic and developmental challenges. Kumar (1983) presents a three-fold perspective in assessing the contributions of NAM and argues that the level of 'conformity between international goals and national interests in the NAM should be considered a measure of its strengths'. Furthermore, there has been 'far greater conformity between international goals and national interests in economic matters than in the politico-security agenda'. This point is contestable, considering that some countries secured economic favours at the cost of their politico-strategic autonomy in decision-making in certain instances.

There is still a broad consensus that NAM did help some of the weakest member countries in coping with their major politico-economic challenges. Kumar's third assessment that, in politico-security affairs, the members were more united on areas concerning either of the superpowers than themselves, worked as a double-edged sword. Over time, internal differences within NAM grew so much that they affected India's own prime security interests – as will be discussed later. On the economic front, several developing countries, especially from the Afro-Asian region, economically benefitted from either or both the superpowers and returned favours in the form of tacit diplomatic support. For India too, the initial years of non-aligned policy brought home considerable economic gains for India, especially from the USSR, which brought in a substantial amount of funds and some projects.

The China-Pakistan axis

China-Pakistan relations have always been a major politico-military challenge, and a cause of strategic anxiety to India. For several decades, the China-Pakistan nexus was complemented by Pakistan-US ties. Undoubtedly, a newly independent India was under-prepared to deal with any major military aggression due to its lack of enough defence resources and military capabilities. In its belief that its neighbours would think alike on territorial boundary issues, the Indian leadership miscalculated Chinese intentions. China-Pakistan ties especially blossomed after the 1962 India-China war and subsequently with Pakistan's decision to unlawfully transfer 5180 sq. km territory to China in 1963. Nixon's rapprochement with China in 1971 and the US support to Pakistan during the Bangladesh war of independence in 1971 turned counter-productive. All these aspects played a vital role in shaping India's policy towards its north-western neighbours.

Compared to the Cold War years, a remarkable shift has taken place in recent years. Among other things, the China-US trade war, their fast-growing strategic rivalry amidst China's growing assertive postures, and the US-Pakistan rift have helped Indo-US ties grow in recent years. Indeed, India and the US are getting closer in strategic terms, but the relations are contingent upon the fast-changing dynamics of the Indo-Pacific and a range of other factors including India's growing anxieties about a belligerent China. The rapid decline of the US-led liberal international order is also a major contributing factor. The US is reaching out to like-minded countries to ensure that the international strategic equilibrium is kept intact. Together, these factors have influenced Indian policymakers' assessment of the situation on the ground vis-à-vis China. A realistic assessment of the situation has also helped India in realising the importance of engaging the US to deter China along the border.

Having faced wars on two fronts, from China in 1962 and Pakistan in 1965, a still militarily weak India under Indira Gandhi inched closer to one of the two superpowers - the USSR. India and the USSR signed the Indo-Soviet Treaty of Peace, Friendship, and Co-operation in August 1971. While one cannot underestimate the importance of maintaining national security and territorial sovereignty, the decision did deliver a serious blow to the normative element of India's non-alignment policy. JB Kriplani, a well-known political leader, warned about these pitfalls as early as in 1959 in his article published in *Foreign Affairs* (Kriplani, 1959, p. 57):

Neutral nations have to resist the temptation of inclining to one side or the other to gain temporary advantage. They must be impartial. They must avoid any action which may undermine the confidence of other nations in their neutrality and do everything that will strengthen it.

Kriplani was a known, perhaps the most vocal, critic of Nehru's China policy. In fact, he was the one who moved a parliamentary no-confidence motion against Prime Minister Nehru in 1963 – in the aftermath of India's defeat at the hands of China in 1962. Explaining the delicate nature of India's dependence on both the US and the USSR, M. K. Rasgotra explains (Rasgotra, 2016, p. 405):

In 1962, solid political and arms support for India came from the United States. A semblance of India's non-aligned status was restored when the USSR also came in with generous military supplies on a sustained basis. But nine years later, to fight off the combined hostility of China and the USA towards India in the war for Bangladesh's liberation, New Delhi had to enter into a virtual military alliance with the USSR.

Thus, albeit temporarily, a non-aligned India showed signs of multi-alignment even in the 1960s to ward-off the China threat. The multi-alignment in Indian foreign policy today is driven by a similar set of strategic concerns and necessities.

Differences within NAM

Over the years, especially during the 1980s, differences among NAM members widened, making it difficult for them to reach a consensus. Most of India's efforts during those times were wasted without a consensus among NAM members (Rajan, 1982).

Early signs of such rifts surfaced in 1955, not just between Nehru and Zhou Enlai – but also between India and SEATO (South East Asia Treaty Organisation). Differences between Nehru and Sukarno also widened before turning frosty in 1961 at the Belgrade conference. The 1962 India-China war, India-Pakistan war of 1965, the creation of the Malaysian federation and an independent Singapore, and, consequently, Indonesia's *Konfrontasi* (confrontation with Malaysia) in 1965 further damaged NAM. Assessing NAM's performance, M. K. Rasgotra states (Rasgotra, 2016, p. 405) that from Delhi's perspective, despite the prestige and respect it commanded over the developing world, in India's three crises moments – China's invasion of India in 1962, India-Pakistan war of 1965, and during the 1971 Bangladesh war – NAM chose to stay non-aligned between India, China, and Pakistan.

NAM members took the non-intervention norm a little too seriously to the extent of overexploiting the same. In several disputes among the members, the use of institutional mediation was not explored sufficiently to extract gains. A judicious use of good offices through a specialised agency was also not witnessed. From the late 1970s onwards, NAM became a victim of its internal bickering – with several countries from West Asia, South Asia, and Southeast Asia working at cross-purposes with one another. A further tilt towards the USSR also weakened the normative foundations of NAM. That said, NAM and its leading proponents did not have the luxury to think these issues through, as one could do in hindsight. Perhaps intending to answer these questions, scholars divide NAM's Cold War history into two phases (Harshe, 1990, p. 399). While politico-diplomatic dimensions dominated the first phase, starting right after India gained independence (and even before it; in 1944) and staying in existence till the early seventies, the second phase was marked by the predominance of economic and developmental issues. It lasted around two decades until the arrival of the post-Soviet unipolar world dominated by the US:

India could not sustain the regional and global systemic pressures exerted on it. Consequently, the normative aspirations of India faded away as it failed to pay enough attention to its military and security capabilities. Sadly, for India, the systemic factors were far too powerful to ignore. India did not have many choices to deal with a security deadlock with China, which eventually ended with India's loss in the 1962 war.

In addition to exposing India's security vulnerabilities, it also exposed the rifts within the Afro-Asian world, particularly India's South and Southeast Asian neighbours. India realised that without strong military capabilities and some direct or indirect support from a superpower, it would not be able to safeguard and further its politico-strategic and economic interests. It was also after the 1962 war that several non-aligned countries sought overt or covert support from either of the two blocs and their respective leading powers – the US and the USSR.

The Indian leadership also failed to take into account the domestic political developments in China, particularly the emergence of the People's Republic of China where aggressive nationalism and rectifying the so-called 'historical mistakes' were the key foundational pillars. Not paying enough attention to such critical details and perceiving China as just another post-Colonial state was a big mistake. India's support to China was marked by a misplaced euphoria that clouded its ability to comprehensively assess the situation with its newly independent neighbour. Consequently, India failed to get a better sense of where Mao Zedong was coming from. History and popular culture are critical tools in making sense of a nation-state's likely behaviour in a given situation. Unlike India, which gained independence through a non-violent peaceful struggle led by Mahatma Gandhi, the People's Republic of China was built under the leadership of Mao. Perhaps, it was a mistake to believe that the two countries would approach foreign relations and boundary issues in the same manner. China was a wounded nation on whose face the scars of imperial exploitation and national humiliation were visible. Unlike India, it was determined to correct history and was preparing for a complete unification by way of gaining territorial control over its 'lost territories' – Tibet and Taiwan.

This lack of appreciation of Chinese history coupled with an fragmentary assessment of India's national and territorial security challenges cost India heavily. India's own historical experience in working with the British Indian government also shaped its boundary response to China.

Norms over power

To a great extent, a defining feature of India's non-alignment policy was an unconventional approach driven by the desire to carve out its own space in a power politics-ridden bipolar international system (Harshe, 1990). True, India (and many of its peers) flip-flopped in that endeavour. However, considering the potential gains such an approach was worth the risk. Dulles's rather bitter criticism of non-alignment as a 'obsolete, 'immoral' and 'short-sighted' conception did not go down well with India (Patrick, 2012). Personal rapport between political leaders and policymakers has always been an important factor shaping relations – something which did play a role in turning India cold towards the US especially during the Nixon years.

India's own non-aligned policy was not the best fit in a world where countries were increasingly siding with either of the superpowers. For Pakistan, whose foreign policy was totally aimed at addressing the power disparity with India, it was essential to join either of the superpower blocs. With India having turned down the invitation to join a military pact, the US went ahead and signed military pacts with Pakistan, thereby further pushing India towards the other bloc. And yet, India did not sign any defence pact of any kind with the USSR until 1971. Even that decision was driven by the concerns raised by the US warning to India during Bangladesh's war of independence.

From non-alignment to multi-alignment

The end of the Cold War, and the subsequent emergence of the 'unipolar world' led by the US, witnessed the rise of a hegemonic world order, which is now gradually giving way to a 'multiplex world' with its multiple theatres of competition and rivalries among regional and global powers. The relative decline of the US, rising China's revisionist

tendencies, and emergence of the multiplex world order have made the US-India ties more important than ever.

Since the 1990s, India and the US have been trying to get closer and build stronger partnerships. However, this relationship is not devoid of challenges. The US expects India to make clear choices in favour of the US-led coalition. It also expects India to cut off ties with Russia, Iran, and other so-called rogue states. For India, however, these are not just sovereign choices; these are based on hard-headed realistic assessments of the unfolding geopolitical scenario. To protect such decisions while bolstering cooperation with the US (and its allies), ‘strategic autonomy’ and ‘multi-alignment’ have been devised as India’s guiding principles. The decision to stick to Russian defence supplies is deeply embedded in India’s approach to having diversified sources of defence supplies, while Iran is one of the prime partners in the South West Asian region. With the rapidly unfolding situation in Afghanistan, Iran’s role for India has acquired greater salience. Indian policymakers are also careful not to give the impression that their policies are subservient to the US interests. The notion of strategic autonomy has not been pushed aside by Indian policymakers. Explaining India’s understanding of strategic autonomy, the foreign secretary of India Harsh Vardhan Shringla (2020) in his address at the National Defence College in 2020 stated:

The concept of “strategic autonomy” is a function of the prevalent structure of the international order making it a more relative concept as opposed to an absolute one. In today’s multipolar world, all countries are, at some point or the other, susceptible to external pressures As a result, the world around India changed fundamentally in the last few decades. It is also evident that the structural change that shaped the global order was predominantly a result of the shift in the economic balance of power. In addition, new and emerging issues threats from terrorism, cyber security, climate change, and pandemics called for India to adjust its policies to the new realities. Our strategic autonomy thus necessitated the association between an autonomous foreign policy and security decision-making capability and the preservation of material assets, both technical and economic.

Shringla’s statement touches on the essence of India’s approach. A sovereign, independent, and rising non-western power cannot afford to remain oblivious to its strategic interests worldwide. India’s interests in Central Asia, the Persian Gulf, the Arab region, Latin America, Africa, Eurasia, and even in South Asia (Pakistan and Afghanistan) and Southeast Asia (Myanmar) may not necessarily be in sync with that of the US. Even with Vietnam, which has been lauded as one of the most promising US partners in the Indo-Pacific, India’s interests are not the same as those of the US. In Non Alignment 2.0 report, Khilnani et al. (2014, p. 6) state:

Strategic autonomy has been the defining value and continuous goal of India’s international policy ever since the inception of the Republic. Defined initially in the terminology of Non-Alignment, that value we believe continues to remain at the core of India’s global engagements even today, in a world that has changed drastically since the mid-20th century.

Acolytes of the alliance system often tend to target India’s long-standing commitment to strategic autonomy as flawed and pretentious. Such assessments tend to overlook that for rising powers such as India, strategic autonomy functions as a tool to ensure survival and maximise leverage in any given situation To ward off such criticism and sufficiently explain India’s foreign policy approach, Dr. S. Jaishankar, the External Affairs Minister of India, officially pronounced India’s ‘multi-alignment’ policy. With strategic autonomy as one of

its tools, the multi-alignment policy aims to engage as many international stakeholders and partners as possible, based on India's own politico-strategic and economic calculations.

Highlighting the importance of multi-alignment in Indian foreign policy, Jaishankar states (Jaishankar, 2020, p. 93):

Taking off on non-alignment, it is sometimes useful to speak of multi-alignment. It appears more energetic and participative as compared to an earlier posture of abstention or non-involvement.

He adds that multi-alignment facilitates a weaker player in soliciting or manipulating stronger forces to its own advantage (Jaishankar, 2020, p. 62). Jaishankar's reiteration of 'multi-alignment' in Indian foreign policy sums up the aspirations and strategic orientations of a rising India.

The critical importance of a deeper partnership with the US and its allies cannot be overstated. However, India is seemingly unwilling to compromise on its strategic autonomy in making foreign policy choices. This is witnessed in the ongoing Russia-Ukraine conflict, where despite the Western criticism and pressure, India has not gone against Russia citing its dependence on Moscow for defence equipment and regional strategic considerations involving China. Partnership with countries such as Iran and Russia is pivotal to India's presence in their respective areas of strategic influence. It is Russia, after all, with which India has opened a direct and dedicated channel of communication – a hotline between Russian President Vladimir Putin and Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi – to deal with the situation post-US withdrawal from Afghanistan. Likewise, India's long-standing partnership with Iran would help India effectively deal with its strategic vulnerabilities emanating out of the Taliban takeover of Afghanistan. Both these issues are critical in shaping India's relations with the US. Sensing India's growing ties with the US, Russia has also normalised ties with Pakistan, compelling India to pursue 'multi-alignment' in its foreign policy, which may be seen as a pro-active, action-oriented, and more forthcoming version of the non-alignment policy. Highlighting the key facets of multi-alignment in India's foreign policy, Jaishankar states (Jaishankar, 2020, pp. 16–17):

For the near term, India has little choice but to pursue a mix of multiple approaches, some orthodox and others more imaginative. But in all of them, partnerships with global interests could make a significant difference. Much of that would revolve around the West and Russia. But China, now the world's second-largest economy, can hardly be disregarded in any calculation. Leveraging them all may not be easy but still no less necessary for that. Mastering mind games and playing hardball are also musts in a more visceral world. To do all that, it is vital that we come to terms with its complex dynamics. Only then can India successfully execute strategic policies for a new era.

Clearly, despite India's attempts to inch closer to the West, its pursuit of multi-alignment is likely to continue along with some time-tested elements of non-alignment. As S.D. Muni also noted in one of his social media comments (Muni, 2022):

Dr Jaishankar's statement that India cannot be a "pale imitation" of others defines Modi foreign policy's (Modi's multi-alignment policy) Nehruvian moment. This is what 'non-alignment' and 'strategic autonomy' were all about.

Recent events such as the US withdrawal from Afghanistan, its withdrawal from multi-lateral economic frameworks such as the Trans Pacific Partnership (TPP), and policy flip-

flops on Indo-Pacific projects demonstrate that more than its commitment, the US policy endurance will be scrutinised by its friends in the region. Small, middle and rising powers of the Indo-Pacific region are still uncertain about the sincerity and endurance of the US commitment to the region on military, diplomatic, and economic fronts under all circumstances. These security anxieties have motivated ASEAN countries to practise hedging in their foreign policies. A sustainable commitment of the US is a major factor shaping their national priorities and policies, and justifiably so. India's multi-alignment policy cannot be appreciated without embedding it in the historical context and realities therein.

Conclusion

India's non-alignment policy during the Cold War years was based on both idealism and pragmatism. Aligned with normative principles, it helped India steer clear of bloc politics. During the Cold War period, India not only had to focus on nation-building but also had several pressing issues to deal with such as the border conflicts with China and Pakistan, turbulence in the Indian subcontinent, and concerns related to nuclear weapons.

Times have changed and non-alignment (in its original form) is no longer the mainstay of contemporary Indian foreign policy. Considering that the systemic realities of international relations have changed, it seems logical to shed some of the notions of non-alignment attached to the Cold War times as well. With regard to non-alignment - a major development that has taken place is India's greater insistence on 'strategic autonomy', and the pursuit of multi-alignment under the Modi 2.0 government. The ongoing Russia-Ukraine conflict, widening rift between Russia and the West, and the US-China tensions – all these developments underline creeping polarisation, though with distinct differences, in contemporary global politics. India's (and even Indonesia's) claims to play a peace role in Ukraine war and now efforts to articulate the voice of the global south fall into the non-alignment mode although with several notable changes. Considering the fluid nature of international relations and great power dynamics, India is looking for a sufficiently wide strategic window – elbow room of sorts to manoeuvre effectively in regional and international scenarios.

It is this insistence on multi-alignment that gives India the wiggle room to keep its defence ties intact with Russia and strategic cooperation with Iran functional while inching closer to the US and its Asian allies via the Quad. The sudden withdrawal of the US troops from Afghanistan and its willingness to engage China again is a sure sign of the unpredictability of international politics. India seems cognisant of these developments and has tried to keep its multi-alignment policy intact as the mainstay of foreign policy formulation. India's insistence on multi-alignment policy also serves as a fine tribute to some of its cherished normative principles of non-alignment, even as multi-alignment has brought in stronger elements of hard-headed and pragmatic notions of foreign policy-making.

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ORCID

Rahul Mishra  <http://orcid.org/0000-0002-4470-3766>

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